

THE FIX for Cravings — Session 3: Long-Term Craving Freedom — 20 min

Video File Bonus2-Fix-Session3.mp4 (progress tracker slide; Q&A text overlays) · **Resources** Cravings Fix Workbook.pdf (Session 3 pages: habit audit, relapse plan template, freedom page) · **Xp** 10 · Create a relapse plan (PDF upload) and share your "fix" success in the forum

Target runtime 20 min · 1,852 spoken words · ≈ 12.3 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 13.7 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

The hardest part of changing a craving isn't the first week. It's month four, when the novelty is gone, the tools feel ordinary, and something in life goes sideways. That's when most people slide, and that's when the people who've built what I call craving freedom don't. The difference is not strength. It's a plan for month four, written in month one. This session is that plan.

0:30–6:30 **MAINTENANCE: AUDITS AND RELAPSE PLANS**

[VISUAL: Slide: "Habit audit: every month, three questions."]

Maintenance has two tools. The first is the habit audit, and it ties straight to Module Seven. Once a month, three questions. Which tools am I still using? Which cues have crept back: the drawer refilled, the show and the snack reunited, the coffee

moved to three p.m.? And what changed in my life that changed my cravings: sleep, stress, a season, a relationship? Cravings are signals, and a rising craving in month four is usually reporting a change somewhere else. The audit reads the report. The workbook has the three questions on a single page you fill in on the first of the month.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Relapse prevention: Marlatt's model. The slip is not the fall. The story is."]

The second tool is the relapse plan, and I want to teach the science properly, because it's some of the most useful in addiction psychology. Alan Marlatt studied why people who had changed a behavior returned to it, and found the pattern was almost never a single slip. It was what happened after: the abstinence violation effect, in which one lapse triggers a story, "I've blown it, I'm back where I started, I might as well," and the story does the damage the lapse didn't. Polivy and Herman found the same in dieters, the what-the-hell effect. And Adams and Leary showed the antidote in the *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*: people guided to respond to a lapse with self-compassion ate less afterward than those who weren't.

So the relapse plan has four parts, and it's written before you need it. One: the high-risk situations. Be specific. "The week before my period." "Travel." "The night after a negative test." "Mother visiting." Two: the early warning signs. "I start buying 'for guests.'" "I skip the walk twice." "Bedtime drifts past eleven." Three: the slip script, the exact sentence you'll say after eating the thing: "That was a slip, not a fall. I'm going to drink a glass of water and do the next thing on my plan." Four: the reset, the three tiny actions you'll take in the next twenty-four hours, and the person you'll text the word "reset" to. The workbook has this as a one-page template, and completing it is your action for this session.

One more piece of Marlatt's work that I find freeing: he found that people who expected occasional lapses and planned for them did better than people who aimed for perfection. Perfection is a relapse risk. A plan for imperfection is protection.

Let me walk you through a relapse plan filled in, so you can see the shape. High-risk situations: the week before my period; my mother-in-law's visits, which come with a full biscuit tin; the night after a scan. Early warning signs: I start

keeping "a little something" in the car; I skip the after-dinner walk two nights running; I'm in bed with my phone at eleven. Slip script: "That was a slip, not a fall. Water, then the walk tomorrow." Reset: text my sister the word "reset"; protein-first breakfast tomorrow; the ten-minute pause at the first craving; bed by ten. That plan fits on an index card, and the index card lives in the kitchen drawer where the biscuits used to be.

6:30–11:30 FERTILITY IMPACT: STABLE BLOOD SUGAR, HORMONE HARMONY

[VISUAL: Slide: "Glycemic load and ovulatory infertility (European Journal of Clinical Nutrition); fast food and time to pregnancy (Human Reproduction)."]

Let me close the loop on why craving freedom is a fertility practice, with the research laid out plainly. In the Nurses' Health Study, Jorge Chavarro's team found that women whose diets carried a higher glycemic load, more fast-digesting carbohydrate, had a higher risk of ovulatory infertility, published in the European Journal of Clinical Nutrition. In a large Australian and international cohort of first pregnancies, published in Human Reproduction, women who ate fast food four or more times a week before conception took longer to become pregnant and had a higher risk of infertility than

women who rarely did, while those who ate fruit three or more times a day conceived faster. In women with PCOS, a low-glycemic diet improved insulin sensitivity and menstrual regularity in a trial in the American Journal of Clinical Nutrition. For men, the Salas-Huetos review found sugar-sweetened drinks and processed food associated with poorer semen quality. And across nearly four thousand couples in the study in Epidemiology, a daily sugary drink meant about twenty percent lower odds of conceiving each month, for both partners.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Stable blood sugar → stable insulin → clearer hormone signaling."]

The thread is insulin. Stable blood sugar means stable insulin; stable insulin means the ovaries aren't being pushed toward extra androgens and the whole hormonal conversation between brain, ovary, and testis runs with less noise. That's what "hormone harmony" means when I use the phrase: not a mystical balance, a signaling system with less static. Every craving you ride out, every swap with protein and fat, every early night, is a little less static. That's the fertility impact of THE FIX, and it's measurable in the research.

And one more, because it's about the kind of freedom I mean. A body that isn't riding a blood-sugar rollercoaster has steadier energy, steadier mood, and steadier patience, and those are the qualities the rest of this journey, the waiting, the appointments, the conversations, will ask of you most. Freedom from cravings is liberation. It's fuel for the miracle ahead.

There's a longer horizon to this too, and it's the reason THE FIX sits inside a course about family. The relationship with food that you build now is the one a child will watch. The parent who can have one square of chocolate with attention, who doesn't eat in secret, who doesn't moralize about "good" and "bad" food, who goes for a walk when the day was hard, is teaching all of that without a word. Craving freedom is not only yours. It's one of the first things your family will inherit, through the marks on the cells being built this month and through the ordinary example of a Tuesday evening.

11:30–17:30 Q&A: YOUR QUESTIONS

[VISUAL: Q&A text overlays, one question at a time.]

Now your questions, from the forum.

"How do I handle cravings when I'm traveling?" Travel breaks every cue and every routine, so plan the environment before you go. Pack the swaps: walnuts, dark chocolate, a protein bar with a short ingredient list, tea bags. Eat protein at breakfast wherever you are; hotel eggs are your friend. Walk on arrival. And lower the bar: on the road, the goal is no sweet alone and one honest night's sleep, not the full plan.

"What about the days before my period?" Cravings rise, energy falls, and it's hormones, not weakness. Add protein and fat to every meal that week, expect the wave to be bigger, use the pause and the fix smoothie more often, and don't audit yourself on those days. Write it in the tracker so you can see the pattern next month and plan for it.

"My partner keeps bringing sweets home. What do I do?" Module Six, not Module Two. An "I" statement: "I feel scared when the sweets are on the counter, because I'm working so hard, and I'd like them kept out of sight." Ask for one thing, not for them to change their eating. And the craving date is your friend here; it gives you both something to do on the hard evenings that isn't a negotiation about the pantry.

"Are artificial sweeteners a good swap?" Not the way people hope. The research is mixed, but intensely sweet tastes keep the sweet expectation alive and give you none of the protein, fat, and fiber that quiets the loop. A diet soda occasionally is not a crisis; six a day is the old groove in a new costume. The better swap is the berry-basil sparkling water.

"Does it get easier?" Yes, and I'll tell you how it gets easier, because it isn't the way people expect. The cravings don't vanish. They get quieter and rarer, and, more importantly, they stop meaning anything. A craving at month six is a passing thought, not a crisis, because you've ridden a hundred of them and you know what's on the other side. That's what freedom feels like: not the absence of the wave, but the certainty that you can surf it.

"What do I do about the guilt from the years before?" The body clears. The cells being built now are built from now. The insulin environment of the next three months starts today, whatever the last ten years held. You're not making up for the past; you're preparing the future, and only one of those is your job. Set the guilt down. It doesn't get a seat at the table, and it never helped you eat one vegetable.

"How do I explain this to friends who think I'm being extreme?" You don't have to explain, and if you do, keep it short and about you: "I've learned that sugar was running my evenings and I'm changing that." Not a lecture, not a conversion. The people who love you will notice you have more energy and ask. The ones who tease are usually negotiating with their own drawer. And at a party, the fix is simple: eat protein before you go, hold a sparkling water, and enjoy the one thing you actually want with the mindful first bite.

"I slipped badly last week. Have I undone everything?" No. Lally's research: a missed day doesn't matter. The body clears: a week of sugar doesn't undo three months of steadier insulin, and the next three months start today. Say the slip script, do the reset, and text your person. You didn't fall. You slipped, and you're already back on the path, because you're here asking.

17:30–19:30 WRAP AND HEART-LED CLOSE

[VISUAL: Progress tracker slide: a simple month-by-month line labeled "cravings that won," drifting down and settling low.]

Here's what the long view looks like. The number of cravings that win drifts down over the first two months, and then it stops dropping and settles somewhere low. That settling is the freedom. From there, your job is the monthly audit, the relapse plan in the drawer, the two tools you've kept, and grace on the weeks that wobble. That's all. You don't have to fight this forever. You have to know what to do when it shows up, and now you do.

As someone who lived inside cravings for years and built a life outside them, I want to leave you with the sentence I wish someone had said to me at the start: you are not weak, you were wired, and wiring can be rewired. You've just done it, in three sessions and a few weeks of practice. Fuel your body for the miracle ahead, and let this freedom be one of the first things your family inherits from you.

19:30–20:00 ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Cravings Fix Workbook → Create your relapse plan (PDF upload) → Share your 'fix' success in the forum (10 XP)."]

Complete the relapse plan template in the Cravings Fix Workbook and upload it, then share your fix success in the forum, however small, for ten XP. And listen to the session-

summaries audio whenever you need the three sessions in four minutes. Thank you for doing this work with me.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Cravings Fix Workbook.pdf, Session 3 pages (monthly habit audit, four-part relapse plan template, Q&A notes, freedom page) and session summaries.mp3 (embedded).
ACTION 1: Create your relapse plan and upload it; share your fix success in the forum (10 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Replays 1 and 2 in the navigation bar; the alumni group.

The Q&A section answers questions posted in the forum after Sessions 1 and 2. The six questions below are the most common; Cynthia can substitute or add live questions. Show each question as a text overlay.